will be prevented by whatever means may be necessary from taking action against any part of the Western Hemisphere."[21]

Shortly before issuing the statement, Kennedy had met with congressional leaders. He asked for their consent to call up as many as 150,000 soldiers to deal with Cuba and possibly another international crisis but argued against an immediate invasion of the island. According to him, the missiles spotted on the island were not a threat to the United States: "We are not talking about nuclear warheads." He was also against a blockade, which would constitute an "act of war." In that connection he also mentioned Berlin. "I think Berlin is coming to some kind of climax this fall, one way or another, before Christmas," Kennedy told the congressional leaders. Khrushchev's Berlin bluff had a powerful hold on the president.[22]